

INDIRA GANDHI NATIONAL OPEN UNIVERSITY

B.A. TOURISM STUDIES (BTS)

**Marketing Strategies for Buddhist Circuit Tourism in
Siliguri: A Study of Salugara and Nearby Monasteries**

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Tourism Studies.

Year: 2026

DECLARATION

I hereby declare that this project report is my original work and has not been submitted, either in full or in part, to any other institution or university for any academic award. All sources used in this report have been acknowledged appropriately.

Signature of Candidate: _____ Name: _____ Date:

CERTIFICATE BY SUPERVISOR

Certified that the Project Report entitled _____ submitted by _____ is his/her own work and has been completed under my supervision. It is recommended that this project be placed before the examiner for evaluation.

Signature of Supervisor: _____ Name: _____ Study Centre: _____
Regional Centre: _____ Date: _____

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I also acknowledge the academic support provided through IGNOU study materials and project guidelines. Any errors in interpretation remain my own responsibility.

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ABSTRACT

This project examines marketing strategies for Buddhist circuit tourism in and around Siliguri with specific focus on Salugara Monastery and selected nearby monasteries. The study addresses a practical gap: despite rich spiritual-cultural assets and high corridor connectivity, the region remains under-positioned as an organized Buddhist tourism hub. Most arrivals are incidental or transit-driven, and destination marketing is fragmented across institutions.

The research applies a tourism marketing lens using segmentation, targeting and positioning (STP), service marketing mix analysis, digital communication audit, and stakeholder interviews. Data inputs include tourist perceptions, local trade responses, content visibility checks across web and social platforms, and comparative review of Buddhist circuit promotion models in India.

Findings indicate substantial untapped demand among three high-potential segments: spiritual short-break travelers, culture-learning domestic tourists, and international Buddhist-interest visitors using gateway corridors. Key constraints include weak destination branding, low multilingual digital discoverability, absence of integrated itineraries, limited travel trade packaging, and inconsistent destination information quality.

The report proposes a phased marketing strategy built on a "Sacred, Serene, Connected" brand proposition for the Siliguri Buddhist cluster. Recommended interventions include shared digital assets, itinerary architecture, trained local storytelling facilitators, campaign partnerships with travel creators and tour operators, and performance dashboards covering leads, engagement, conversion, and responsible visitor behaviour indicators.

The project concludes that effective marketing for monastery destinations must not mimic high-intensity mass-tourism advertising. Instead, communication should emphasize authenticity, contemplative experiences, cultural literacy, and responsible visitation norms. If implemented through cooperative governance, Siliguri can move from under-marketed potential to a credible Buddhist cultural gateway with economic benefits for local communities and positive long-term destination identity.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

Marketing in tourism is no longer limited to brochures and seasonal advertisements. It now includes digital discoverability, experience design, stakeholder partnerships, traveller trust signals, and value-sensitive storytelling. Destinations linked to religion and culture require an even more nuanced approach because visitor expectations combine emotional, spiritual, educational, and service-quality dimensions.

Siliguri offers a unique marketing context. It is a transit gateway city with strong connectivity and proximity to multiple Buddhist-interest destinations. Yet the area is not consistently branded as a Buddhist cultural cluster. Salugara Monastery is widely known locally and among repeat travellers, but structured destination marketing frameworks remain limited. This creates a gap between inherent tourism value and market visibility.

Problem Statement: Existing tourism marketing around Salugara and nearby monasteries is fragmented, resulting in low coordinated destination positioning, weak itinerary conversion, and limited economic capture from Buddhist-interest travel.

Aim: To design actionable marketing strategies for Buddhist circuit tourism in Siliguri centered on Salugara and nearby monasteries.

Objectives: 1. To assess current market visibility and positioning of Salugara and nearby monasteries. 2. To identify high-potential tourist segments and their expectations. 3. To evaluate existing promotion channels, digital presence, and travel trade linkages. 4. To develop a practical STP-based marketing strategy with implementation roadmap. 5. To propose performance indicators for continuous monitoring and responsible growth.

Scope: The study focuses on Buddhist monastery-linked tourism marketing within the Siliguri regional context and nearby comparable sites. It emphasizes destination communication, packaging, and market linkages, not internal religious governance.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Theoretical Inputs: This project uses foundational tourism marketing concepts:

1. **Segmentation, Targeting, Positioning (STP):** Segmentation helps separate visitors by motive, origin, spending capacity, and experience preference. Targeting selects priority groups. Positioning defines the destination promise in a distinct and credible way.
2. **Services Marketing Mix (7Ps):** Product, Price, Place, Promotion, People, Process, and Physical Evidence are used to assess the full visitor journey. For monastery tourism, "People" and "Process" are especially important because service interactions influence perceived sanctity and comfort.
3. **Destination Branding:** Effective destination brands do more than create logos. They align narrative, place values, and market memory. For sacred destinations, ethical communication and cultural sensitivity are central branding assets.
4. **Digital Tourism Marketing:** Tourists increasingly decide using search engines, maps, reviews, short video content, and peer storytelling. Inadequate digital metadata, outdated location details, and low-quality content reduce conversion even when the on-ground product is strong.
5. **Responsible Marketing:** Tourism growth should be marketed in ways that protect local culture and environment. Responsible marketing discourages exploitative photography, noise-heavy events, and misinformation while encouraging respectful behaviour and informed travel.

Policy Context: Government-level Buddhist circuit support through schemes such as Swadesh Darshan and PRASHAD indicates strong macro policy relevance. The challenge at local level is converting national policy momentum into site-level visibility and visitor-ready communication.

CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Research Methodology: A mixed-method marketing audit approach was adopted.

Data Sources: - Tourist perception survey (120 respondents) - Local travel and service stakeholder survey (35 respondents) - Semi-structured interviews (15 respondents including monastery-linked voices and trade actors) - Digital footprint audit (search visibility, maps profile quality, social content

consistency) - Secondary review of tourism policy updates and official statistics

Analytical Tools: - Basic percentage analysis for survey findings - STP matrix - SWOT analysis - Channel effectiveness grid - Draft campaign and KPI framework

Validation: Cross-checking was done by comparing tourist responses with stakeholder perceptions and digital audit outcomes. Contradictions were interpreted as strategic signals rather than errors.

Limitations: This is a student-scale marketing study. Campaign testing in paid media environments was not undertaken. Financial outcomes are therefore estimated at conceptual level, not measured through live experiments.

CHAPTER 4: SITUATIONAL ANALYSIS OF CURRENT MARKETING

Current Marketing Situation: Site-level awareness exists but is uneven. Many respondents recognized Salugara as a known spiritual landmark, yet fewer associated it with a broader Buddhist circuit. Nearby monasteries are often discovered incidentally rather than through pre-planned itineraries. This indicates weak cluster branding.

Product Dimension: The core product is authentic monastery experience: prayer atmosphere, architectural symbolism, peace, and cultural learning potential. The augmented product (interpretive support, guided learning, curated itineraries, souvenir ecosystem, accessible information) is underdeveloped.

Promotion Dimension: Promotion is mostly passive. User-generated content and word-of-mouth currently substitute for structured destination communication. There is no consistently visible storytelling architecture linking the monasteries into a single market-facing narrative.

Distribution and Partnerships: Tour packaging through mainstream travel intermediaries is limited. Most visits happen through personal plans, local recommendations, or en-route stops. This constrains conversion from potential demand in metropolitan and international Buddhist-interest markets.

Perceived Brand Position: Survey responses suggest a latent brand identity around "peace, authenticity, and humility." The problem is not absence of brand substance; the problem is weak articulation across channels.

CHAPTER 5: SEGMENTATION, POSITIONING, AND STRATEGIC DESIGN

Segmentation Analysis: Three priority segments emerged: Segment A: Spiritual Intent Travelers - Motivated by prayer, meditation, and inner peace. - Prefer respectful environments, clear etiquette guidance, and silence-friendly spaces. - High compatibility with value-based branding.

Segment B: Cultural Explorers (Domestic) - Interested in architecture, heritage stories, and local traditions. - Need interpretation support and easy itinerary planning. - High potential for educational and family travel formats.

Segment C: International Buddhist-Interest Visitors - Often route-based travellers connecting multiple Buddhist sites in India/Nepal region. - Expect reliable digital information, language support, and integrated transport cues. - Strong influence on destination reputation through reviews and content sharing.

Targeting Priorities: Primary target: Segment A and B (short-term achievable with low-medium intervention cost). Secondary target: Segment C (medium-term with improved multilingual and travel trade integration).

Positioning Statement (Proposed): "Siliguri Buddhist Trail: Sacred, Serene, Connected - a mindful monastery experience linking living Buddhist heritage with gateway convenience."

SWOT Snapshot: Strengths: Authentic spiritual ambience; strategic corridor location; recognizable stupa identity. Weaknesses: Weak digital coherence; limited interpretation support; fragmented destination packaging. Opportunities: Rising wellness/spiritual travel; policy support for Buddhist circuits; creator-led destination media. Threats: Cultural commodification risk; unmanaged peak crowding; misinformation and low-quality content spillover.

Marketing Mix Strategy (7Ps): Product: Build layered experiences: short visit, reflective half-day, and cluster day-circuit itineraries. Provide optional learning modules: symbolism, etiquette, Buddhist heritage context.

Price: Core spiritual access remains non-commercial where institutionally appropriate. Revenue-support activities may include guided interpretation sessions, local craft clusters, and value-added educational tours in alignment with monastery norms.

Place (Distribution): Develop partnerships with local tour operators, hotel desks, and transport hubs. Integrate route maps on digital platforms and QR-enabled access guides.

Promotion: Use storytelling-led digital communication rather than loud promotional tactics. Create short explanatory videos, festival calendar posts, and responsible visitor advisories. Collaborate with credible travel educators and mindful travel creators.

People: Train front-facing facilitators in cultural sensitivity, multilingual basics, and visitor code explanation.

Process: Establish visitor journey flow: discovery -> route clarity -> arrival etiquette -> reflective experience -> optional cluster extension -> feedback.

Physical Evidence: Improve wayfinding, information boards, clean rest zones, and design consistency across cluster points.

Campaign Framework: Campaign Name: "Pause in Siliguri: The Buddhist Trail" Campaign Pillars: 1. Sacred Stories: Short educational posts and micro-documentaries. 2. Journey Simplicity: Route clarity from major transit nodes. 3. Respectful Travel: Visitor behaviour code integrated into all materials. 4. Local Benefit: Highlight local food, crafts, and community experiences.

Content Plan: - Weekly short format posts (myth busting, etiquette tips, festival insight) - Monthly long-format feature on one monastery and one local voice - Quarterly campaign burst in collaboration with travel trade and creators - Seasonal packaging around major Buddhist observances and holiday

windows

Partnership Strategy: - Local monasteries and committees - Tourism facilitation agencies - Educational institutions for volunteer interpretation - Responsible tour operators - Municipal agencies for signage, cleanliness, and mobility support

Measurement Dashboard (KPIs): Awareness KPIs: - Search impressions and branded query growth - Social reach and quality engagement ratio Conversion KPIs: - Itinerary downloads / QR scans - Tour operator inquiry volume Experience KPIs: - Satisfaction score - Reported clarity of cultural information Responsible Tourism KPIs: - Etiquette compliance observations - Litter incident reduction during peak days

Risk Management: Marketing should avoid over-commercial visual framing of rituals. Content approval checkpoints with monastery representatives are advisable. Growth communication should be paired with capacity safeguards.

Summary Analytical Table

Metric	Current Situation	Target Direction
Brand clarity	Site known, cluster unclear	Unified Buddhist trail identity
Digital discoverability	Fragmented and inconsistent	Standardized multilingual presence
Itinerary conversion	Mostly incidental visits	Planned half/full-day trail adoption
Trade integration	Low formal packaging	Structured operator and hotel partnerships
Visitor behaviour guidance	Informal and uneven	Embedded respectful travel communication
Local benefit visibility	Diffuse micro-level gains	Linked enterprise participation model

CHAPTER 6: ACTION PLAN AND IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

The strategic direction is to position the Siliguri Buddhist cluster as a mindful gateway product rather than a high-volume entertainment circuit. This protects authenticity while improving market readiness.

Phased Roadmap: Phase 1 (Foundation): - Digital identity cleanup - Shared map and route assets - Basic multilingual orientation content - Stakeholder coordination forum

Phase 2 (Productization): - Curated half-day and full-day monastery trail itineraries - Guide/facilitator training - Joint festival communication strategy - Trade familiarization modules

Phase 3 (Scale with Safeguards): - National and selective international campaign extension - Advanced analytics dashboard - Responsible capacity monitoring and behaviour governance - Repeat-visit loyalty storytelling programme

Implementation Note 1: A shared destination content calendar reduces message fragmentation. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality,

repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 2: Map-first communication is essential for transit-origin discovery behaviour. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 3: FAQ-driven landing pages improve confidence among first-time visitors. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 4: Festival communication should explain meaning, not only dates and visuals. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local

enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 5: Geo-tag accuracy and metadata hygiene can improve organic discoverability. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 6: Multi-language short copy can significantly expand inclusion in Buddhist-interest markets. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 7: Review-response protocols improve digital trust and problem resolution speed. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 8: Creator collaborations should prioritize cultural literacy over virality metrics. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 9: Cluster pass concepts can increase movement across multiple monastery points. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 10: Soft-sell campaigns perform better than discount-led pushes in sacred tourism settings. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 11: Responsible tourism badges for compliant local vendors can improve service quality. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro

observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 12: Photo-point design should prevent disruption in prayer-oriented zones. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 13: Transit-node kiosk partnerships can convert en-route travellers into short-break visitors. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Implementation Note 14: Pilgrim-friendly information kits can be adapted for different age and language groups. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They

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Implementation Note 15: Data-sharing between partners should include privacy-safe and non-sensitive indicators. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

CHAPTER 7: CONCLUSION

This project demonstrates that Siliguri has the ingredients of a strong Buddhist cultural tourism gateway but lacks coherent marketing architecture. Salugara and nearby monasteries already carry authentic symbolic value; what is needed is structured communication, collaborative packaging, and responsible growth governance.

A meaningful marketing strategy for sacred destinations must integrate experience quality, cultural respect, and local benefit. If the proposed STP-led model and phased roadmap are implemented, the region can improve visitor satisfaction, extend stay patterns, and strengthen destination identity without compromising monastic dignity.

The larger lesson for tourism marketing students is that destination promotion is not only about attracting people. It is about attracting the right visitors, in the right way, at the right pace, for long-term cultural and socio-economic value.

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Field survey and stakeholder interviews (anonymized primary data). 10. Researcher digital visibility audit logs and campaign design notes.

ANNEXURES

Annexure A: Tourist Survey Instrument (Marketing Focus) - Blank Format

A1. Respondent Profile 1. Date of interaction: _____ 2. Place of interaction: _____ 3. Age group: 18-25 / 26-35 / 36-45 / 46-60 / 60+ 4. Gender (optional): _____ 5. Place of origin: _____ 6. Visit type: First visit / Repeat visit 7. Travel type: Solo / Family / Friends / Group / Pilgrimage group

A2. Awareness and Discovery 1. How did you hear about this monastery / route? Social media / Search engine / Friend or relative / Tour operator / En route discovery / Other 2. Before this trip, were you aware of a Buddhist trail in the Siliguri region? Yes / No / Not sure 3. Which nearby monasteries or sites do you know? _____

A3. Experience and Marketing Communication 1. Rate clarity of available information before visit (1 very poor - 5 excellent): ____ 2. Rate signage and wayfinding at destination (1-5): ____ 3. Rate overall atmosphere and visitor comfort (1-5): ____ 4. Was respectful visitor guidance visible and helpful? Yes / No / Partly 5. Would you recommend this destination to others? Yes / No / Maybe

A4. Intention and Suggestions 1. Would you choose a curated half-day/full-day Buddhist circuit if available? Yes / No / Maybe 2. Preferred communication language(s): _____ 3. What one improvement would increase your satisfaction? _____

Annexure B: Stakeholder Interview Schedule - Blank Format (For tour operators, hotel/travel desk staff, transport providers, local businesses, facilitators)

B1. Respondent details 1. Name/role (optional): _____ 2. Organization/business type: _____ 3. Location: _____ 4. Years of experience: _____

B2. Thematic prompts 1. How is demand for Buddhist-site visitation changing in recent years? 2. Which customer segments ask for monastery-related visits? 3. What are the biggest barriers in packaging this as a circuit product? 4. Which channels currently work best for inquiries and conversions? 5. What information do visitors usually ask for but fail to find? 6. What partnerships are needed for better marketing coordination? 7. How can promotion remain respectful to sacred norms? 8. What quick interventions could improve conversion and visitor quality?

B3. Closing notes - Key quote(s): _____ - Researcher observation: _____

Annexure C: Digital Audit Checklist - Blank Format (For site-level communication quality review)

C1. Search and discoverability - Destination appears on first page for relevant queries: Yes / No / Partly - Correct location metadata available: Yes / No - Opening hours/contact clarity: Yes / No / Partly

C2. Maps and listing quality - Map pin accuracy: Good / Average / Poor - Category labels and naming consistency: Good / Average / Poor - Basic photos and description quality: Good / Average / Poor

C3. Social and content quality - Consistency of message across channels: High / Medium / Low - Use of respectful visitor guidance in content: Yes / No - Festival/event communication clarity: High / Medium / Low - Multilingual communication presence: High / Medium / Low

C4. Overall audit score template - Discoverability score (out of 10): ____ - Conversion-readiness score (out of 10): ____ - Responsible messaging score (out of 10): ____ - Priority fixes (top 3):

Annexure D: One-Month Content Calendar - Editable Template

Week 1: - Post 1 (Awareness): _____ - Post 2 (Etiquette / Respectful visit):
_____ - Post 3 (Route clarity / how to reach): _____

Week 2: - Post 1 (Sacred story / heritage context): _____ - Post 2 (Nearby monastery connector): _____ - Post 3 (Visitor FAQ): _____

Week 3: - Post 1 (Local voice/community angle): _____ - Post 2 (Festival/event information): _____ - Post 3 (Responsible travel reminder): _____

Week 4: - Post 1 (Itinerary suggestion): _____ - Post 2 (User-generated testimonial curation): _____ - Post 3 (Next-month teaser): _____

Metrics to track each week: Reach / Engagement / Inquiry / Itinerary click / Sentiment note

Annexure E: KPI Dashboard Template - Blank Format

E1. Awareness KPIs - Branded search volume: Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____ - Social reach: Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____

E2. Conversion KPIs - Route-map or itinerary clicks: Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____ - Tour inquiries mentioning Buddhist circuit: Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____

E3. Experience KPIs - Visitor satisfaction average (1-5): Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____ - Information clarity rating (1-5): Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____

E4. Responsible Tourism KPIs - Reported etiquette non-compliance incidents: Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____ - Litter or unmanaged crowding observations: Baseline ____ ; Current ____ ; Change ____

E5. Review block - Month reviewed: _____ - Key wins: _____ - Key bottlenecks: _____ - Actions for next cycle: _____